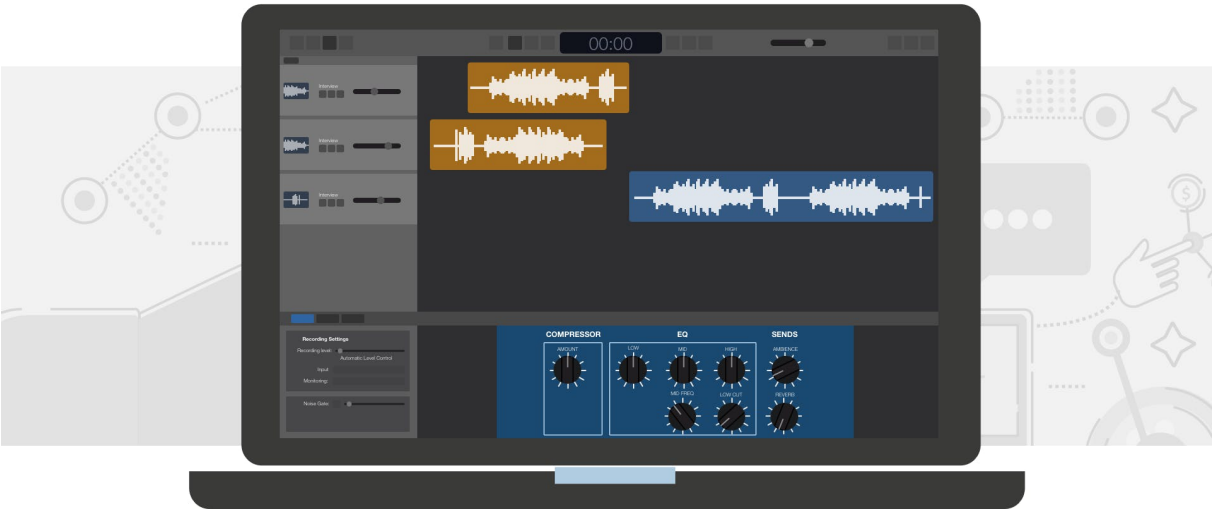


May 05, 2020, https://www.buzzsprout.com/blog/podcast-structure (shortened by Anna Stolz)

How to Structure Your Podcast in 4 Steps

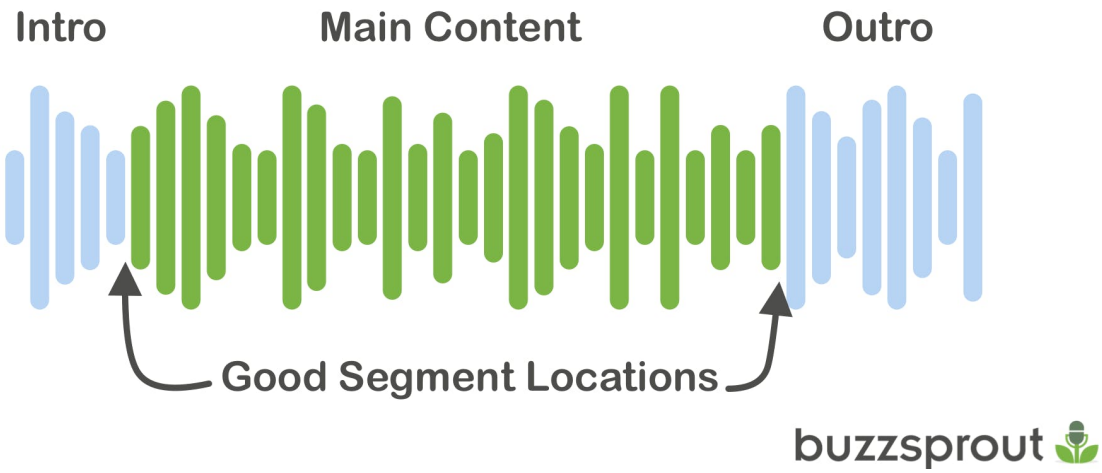
Structuring a podcast episode is like any other creative process: the individual elements have to be in the right order and cadence to make an impact on your audience.

Podcast structure refers to the framework of your show, the flow of its segments, and how you arrange each element to fit together.

So how do you structure a podcast in a way that keeps people listening without sacrificing your creativity and unique style? How can you make each episode entertaining from start to finish, without losing listeners along the way?

Here's a step-by-step guide to crafting the best possible podcast episodes, so each one is as effective, entertaining, and profitable as it can be.

The essential elements of a podcast episode



Podcast episodes have three basic elements: the introduction, main content, and conclusion (with intro and outro music as the bookends of your show).

There's a lot of room for creativity here. You can add distinct segments to your main content section, break up parts of your show with segues and sound effects, and add creative elements with as much production as you want.

Later on, we'll learn how to make each of these sections build on each other, so they work together to engage your listener from start to finish.

Applying structure to your podcast depends on several factors, so let's review the most common podcast structures, and how each one changes the flow of a show.

#1 Choose a podcasting format

There are several podcast styles to choose from, and each one has a slightly different structure.

a) An interview show

Most podcasts feature podcast interviews with a guest or expert in your field. Interview shows give you an endless source of content and make each episode unique.

You can interview guests in person, or record a podcast phone call over Skype or Zoom and edit the conversation together in Audacity (or your favorite editing software).

Genres: This format works for just about any kind of non-fiction podcast

Script template:

- **Podcast Intro**
- **Introduce you and your guest**
- **Podcast interview**
- **Summary**
- **Outro**

b) A solo show

Recording a podcast by yourself has pros and cons, but it's a great option if you don't want to worry about booking guests and enjoy sharing your thoughts directly to listeners.

Solo shows are easy to edit and take less time to produce. The hard part is having enough to say without bouncing off of a guest or a co-host.

Genres: Self-help, spiritual, comedy, music, art, etc.

Script template:

- **Intro**
- **Topic #1**
- **Segue**
- **Topic #2**
- **Segue**
- **Listener emails & social media comments**
- **Summary**
- **Outro**

c) A roundtable podcast

A roundtable podcast is usually two to three times as long as a typical podcast episode and features anywhere from three to ten guests.

The number of guests might change each episode based on who's an expert on that episode's topic, so you have some flexibility.

Genres: Gaming, technology, and long-form podcasts

Script template:

- **Podcast intro**
- **Introduce each guest**
- **Discussion**
- **Audience Q&A**
- **Summary**
- **Outro**

d) A show with multiple co-hosts

Co-hosting with multiple people can be a fun dynamic for a podcast. The challenge with this format is getting everyone together in one place, which is why most shows with multiple co-hosts choose to **record long-distance** over Skype, Zoom, or Google Hangouts.

Genres: comedy podcasts, beginner podcasters, and any show where you want lots of opinions and commentary

Script template:

- **Podcast intro**
- **Introduce each guest**
- **Topic #1**
- **Segue**
- **Topic #2**
- **Summary**
- **Outro**

Now that you have an idea of the different layouts for each format, it's time to decide how long you want your podcast episodes to be.

#2 Decide on your episode length

Setting a time limit for your show gives you a basic foundation to work with, so you can add segments and structure around it.

There's no set rule for how long a podcast should be, and the length depends on your preference, genre, the frequency with which you release episodes, and how much time you have to commit to your show.

Pro tip: A podcast can take six to eight times the length of an episode to create.

#3 Plan ahead by writing a podcast script

Writing a podcast script doesn't mean you have to read off a sheet of paper or have a formal, stilted show.

A podcast script can be anything from a list of bullet-points that help you stay on track to a word-for-word monologue.

A script or guide can also help you decide how to break up your segments, how long to spend on each one, and where to include segues and sponsor ads.

Sketching out a brief outline can save you time editing out unnecessary content in post-production, and gives you a basic idea of how you want to organize your episode.

It's up to you how detailed to make your script/outline; the important thing is to have a rough idea of the flow of your show before you press record or interview your guest.

Plan your podcast interview

A little preparation goes a long way toward making your conversation sound seamless and easy to the listener, and the more prepared you are, the more at ease your guest will be.

Spend some time planning the flow of your podcast interview by jotting down the questions you want to ask your guest, and how you'll transition from one topic to the next.

You can also send your guest your outline ahead of time to ensure you're both on the same page going in.

Outlining is an important part of structuring your episode, but how can you take the elements you've decided to use and put them together to both capture and keep your listener's attention?

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